

PREHISTORIC POOP

COPROLITES



Shark coprolite

Fossilized dung might be one of the last places you would expect to find clues about the lifestyles and habits of prehistoric creatures. However, coprolites (the scientific term for fossilized animal droppings) are a gold mine of valuable information and provide some of the best evidence of what these different animals ate. Coprolites also reveal what kinds of plants grew in the distant past and the types of gut parasites and microorganisms that lived inside the digestive systems of dinosaurs and other prehistoric animals.



MARY ANNING

The famous British fossil hunter Mary Anning was the first person to examine fossilized dung. In 1824, she found odd-looking "stones" full of fish bones among the fossils of an ichthyosaur on the south coast of England and shared her finds with paleontologist William Buckland. Together, they concluded that this meant ichthyosaurs hunted small fish.

The shape and surface pattern of a rock that looks like a coprolite can be matched with dung from modern animals in order to confirm its identity.

This coprolite was found in a fossil-rich region called the Morrison Formation in Utah.

